

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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3 John 1:1

This letter is from John, the elder: The translators have added *John* (see study note on 2 Jn 1:1). • There are several people named Gaius in the New Testament (see [Acts 19:29](#); [20:4](#); [Rom 16:23](#); [1 Cor 1:14](#)); it was a popular name in the Greco-Roman world.

3 John 1:1-4

John begins his letter with a conventional greeting, which includes the identification of the author and addressee, a salutation (dear friend), a wish for the recipient's welfare, and gratitude for some aspect of the friendship.

3 John 1:3

The traveling teachers (literally *brothers*) were probably John's emissaries who traveled from church to church, teaching the Good News and encouraging Christians (see [1:5](#), [10](#)). • you are living according to the truth: Gaius was faithful to the apostolic gospel of Jesus Christ. The false teachers denied the reality of the incarnation or the sacrificial death of Jesus Christ (cp. [1 Jn 4:1-3](#)).

3 John 1:4

As in 2 John (see [2 Jn 1:1-4](#)), John's emphasis is on knowing and following the truth in contrast to Diotrephes and his followers ([3 Jn 1:9](#)).

3 John 1:5

Gaius provided hospitality for the traveling teachers (literally *the brothers*) sent by John from church to church to affirm the apostles' teaching about Christ ([1:7-8](#)). By doing this, Gaius showed that he had received the truth from the apostles and that he was thus faithful to God.

3 John 1:5-8

John now encourages Gaius to continue supporting the traveling teachers whom John had sent out ([1:3](#)).

3 John 1:6

The church here was most likely in Ephesus, where John was probably staying. Ephesus was an important port city in the province of Asia, and the fourth-largest city in the Roman Empire. It became an important city for the Christian community ([Acts 18:19-19:41](#); [1 Tim 1:3](#); [1 Pet 1:1](#); [Rev 2:1-7](#)).

3 John 1:7-8

for the Lord (literally *on behalf of the Name*): John did not need to identify whose name this was because all the early Christians knew that *the Name* represented Jesus Christ (see [Acts 5:41](#)). • The traveling teachers had chosen to accept nothing offered to them from people who are not believers, but to rely fully on the churches for their support. Christians who support legitimate traveling teachers become their partners as they teach the truth (see [Matt 10:41-42](#); [Phil 4:15-19](#)).

3 John 1:9

I wrote to the church about this: This could refer to 1 John or to a letter that is now lost. • Diotrephes was full of pride and self-importance (cp. [1 Tim 3:6](#)), motivated by selfish ambition. • refuses to have anything to do with us: This dissidence was one of the key issues John dealt with in 1 John (see, e.g., [1 Jn 2:19](#); [4:5-6](#)). Diotrephes rejected the teachers sent by John and excommunicated any members of the church who did accept them. He wanted to rule the local church without answering to any outside authority.

3 John 1:9–12

In these verses, John condemns Diotrephes and presents Demetrius as the model of a faithful Christian who lives according to the truth. Gaius is urged to emulate Demetrius.

3 John 1:11

those who do evil: Diotrephes was condemned for his failure to live by the Christian rule of love ([1 Jn 3:10–14](#)). This was how Gaius could be sure that Diotrephes was not living according to the truth. This applies to all who refuse to accept the apostolic teaching about Jesus Christ and refuse to live in fellowship with others who do.

3 John 1:12

Demetrius was the very opposite of Diotrephes, a prime example of one who knows the truth and practices it ([1:3](#)). The placement of Demetrius's name at the end of the letter suggests that he was the one who carried John's letter to Gaius (cp. [Col 4:7–9](#); [1 Pet 5:12](#)). • you know we speak the truth: John wished to protect his honor as a reliable elder over these churches rather than being shamed by any possible usurpation by Diotrephes and other false teachers.

3 John 1:13

pen and ink (literally *ink and reed*): In antiquity, writing was typically done with a stylus shaped from a reed and black carbon ink (see also [2 Jn 1:12](#)).

3 John 1:13–15

As in 2 John, the conclusion of 3 John shows John's desire to make a personal visit and see to the instructions of this letter.

3 John 1:14

Our English idiom face to face parallels the Greek idiom used here (literally *mouth to mouth*; see also [2 Jn 1:12](#)).

3 John 1:15

John closes his letter with his farewell and with greetings to others. • Peace be with you: This was a traditional greeting among the Jews ([Matt 10:12](#); [Luke 10:5–6](#)), which had taken on heightened significance for Christians because Jesus used it after his resurrection ([John 20:19–21](#), [26](#)). • give my personal greetings (literally *greet by name*): Gaius was to greet the friends—that is, those who accept the apostolic gospel and live according to the truth (cp. [3 Jn 1:3–4](#)).